after two days at sea, the ships were caught in a major storm and the larger ship sprang a leak. Suddenly there was panic. Many of the merchants wanted to shift to the smaller vessel immediately, but its crew panicked when faced with a virtual stampede. They cut the cables and sailed off. This further increased the state of panic. The merchants were now forced to throw most of their goods overboard. Fa Xian tells us that he too threw away his water-pitcher, wash-basin and other possessions. He was afraid that the merchants would also throw out his precious cargo of books, but fortunately this did not happen.

Finally, after thirteen days, the storm cleared up. The crew beached the ship on a small island, possibly one of the Andaman and Nicobar islands. The leak was found and repaired before they set sail again. We are told that the mood remained tense because the area was notorious for pirates and the crew was not quite sure about their location. In the end, however, they regained their bearings and set a course for Java.

The ship arrived in Java after ninety days at sea. In common with other Chinese pilgrims who visited India to study Buddhism, Fa Xian saw the world in largely religious terms. The only thing he has to say about Java is that its people were Hindus and not Buddhists (also not entirely accurate given the evidence of Borobodur). After staying in Java for five months, he set sail for China on a very large merchant ship.

The vessel must have been enormous since the crew alone numbered 200. Fa Xian comments that he was very comfortable on this ship. It is possible that ships of this size had private cabins. For over a month, the ship made good progress till it, too, hit a major storm. Yet again, there was panic. Fa Xian tells us that some of his fellow passengers accused him of bringing bad luck. They had probably heard of the storm on his previous voyage and thought that this was too much of a coincidence! Luckily an influential merchant defended him and the matter was settled.

Meanwhile, the ship’s crew realized that they had been blown off-course and were lost. They had been at sea for seventy days by now and were running dangerously short on food and water. Given the desperate situation, some of the more experienced merchants decided to take control of the ship